ignoring the harsh realities of international relations. The optimism and ideals of the liberal thinkers therefore, got a rude shock with the outbreak of the Second World War (WWII) in 1939. The idealists' failure to answer the questions regarding the failure of the League of Nations to prevent the war and also the behaviour of certain states with respect to some others, which aggravated conflict-like situations in the inter-War period ultimately culminating in the Second World War led to severe criticisms.

Contrary to Wilson's hope to spread democracy, Fascism and Nazism grew in Italy and Germany and coupled with this was the rise of authoritarianism in Central and Eastern Europe. The League of Nations proved to be too weak an international organization to control aggressive states. Russia and Germany always had strained relationship with the League. Germany joined the League in 1926 and left in the early 1930s. Following its invasion of Manchuria, Japan left the League. Russia joined the League in 1934 but was expelled in 1940, following its attack on Finland. Britain and France never had regards for the principles of the League. USA, though a forerunner in the creation of the League, could not join it because of the Senate's refusal to ratify the Covenant of the League as well as their intention to pursue their age-old policy of isolationism. Severe economic crisis of the 1930s again forced the states to follow zealously the policy of protectionism rather than interdependence. As some scholars put forth, the situation was like each country for itself, each country trying as best it could to look after its own interests, if necessary, to the detriment of others—the 'jungle' rather than the 'zoo'.[15] Therefore, the stage was ready for a more critical and in-depth understanding of IR.

When the Second World War (1939–1945) finally broke out, the idealists were blamed for their utopian thinking and their legalistic–moralistic assumptions were alleged to be far from the realities of power politics. IR soon came to be occupied with a critique of liberal idealism and out of this emerged a new paradigm—Realism, sometimes also known as *Realpolitik*—an anti-thesis of Idealism. The principal advocates of this worldview were E.H. Carr (1939), George F. Kennan (1954, 1956), Hans J. Morgenthau (1948), Reinhold Niebuhr (1947), Kenneth W. Thompson (1958, 1960) and